likes of Kitchener and the British Oriental Secretary at Cairo, Ronald Storrs.[21] As the war drew to a close, however, and Britain faced considerable expansion to its territorial responsibilities, the issue became more pressing.

The problem was what form this Middle Eastern/Asian body should take and who should ultimately control it. In the opinion of Robert Cecil, what was needed was the creation of an independent department within the government with control over all political, administrative and military aspects of the region for Britain. However, for Hardinge and Sir Ronald Graham (assistant under-secretary), the creation of a separate department that would challenge the Foreign Office's supposed monopoly over Britain's foreign affairs was inconceivable. Instead, they argued for the creation of a Middle Eastern section within their department.[22] As chair of the Eastern Committee, Curzon too was opposed to Cecil's plans, as it threatened to make his position within government defunct. The ex-viceroy was already annoyed at the frequency with which his committee was bypassed by other departments: 'I observe that no questions are referred to us. We have not been summoned for some two months and the Foreign Office policy as regards these countries is formulated and published without reference to us at all.'[23] Curzon's alternative to the suggestions of Montagu and Cecil was to expand the Eastern Committee to include a staff, and that the chair (i.e. he) should be made a secretary of state for the Middle East.[24] Thus, it would seem that while everybody agreed that a co-ordinating body was needed in order to take charge of Britain's affairs in this region, everybody also believed that their department should be in control and nobody was willing to have their current authority diminished. Eventually, however, by August 1918, Cecil had finally managed to convince Balfour, to allow him to establish a Middle Eastern Department. To conciliate Hardinge, Cecil accepted that the department could not be completely removed from the Foreign Office,[25] and he also gave up trying to dissolve the Eastern Committee altogether, although he did believe that the committee should be concerned only with matters of high policy, leaving the practical administrative issues to the new department.[26]

For Curzon, this was the worst possible scenario. Not only had he been passed over to head the new Middle Eastern Department, but he was in